

Hacking and malware

Hackers look for weak spots in a device's security in order to access other people's digital information for personal gain. To do so, they may use malware (short for malicious software). Malware is any type of computer program that damages a device or gains access to sensitive information. Often known as a "virus," malware is designed to spread between devices, infecting each one and collecting or destroying data.



GOOD TO KNOW

Types of malware

Knowing the different types of hacking can help people to be careful.

- A trojan horse is a harmless-looking file that unleashes a program that takes over a computer and potentially its networks.
- Keylogging is a way of monitoring the keys that are used on a computer in order to learn passwords and security data.
- Backdoor programs download malware that grants access to a computer, bypassing its security measures.
- A sniffer is a tracking tool that monitors data to and from a computer in order to obtain passwords and security data.

Protecting against malware

There are programs that protect against malware, but they must be kept up to date in order to be effective. Firewalls are a type of program that stop unauthorized access from unknown users, while antivirus software detects malware and any emails, ads, or messages that contain malware. It then blocks them to keep the computer and its information safe.



△ Stay alert

To reduce the risk of device damage and being hacked, teens should never click on suspicious links, visit unknown websites, or open attachments from strangers.

Distressing content

Because the Internet is largely unregulated, it can be easy to come into contact with distressing content. Some teens may search out upsetting material out of curiosity, while others stumble upon it unintentionally. Some teens are more affected by what they see than others. Explaining that unpleasant, sad, and illegal things happen, and that people can insult and exploit each other in all areas of life, can be difficult for parents, but it helps teens to put confusing and upsetting content into context.



▷ Different responses

Everyone reacts in their own way to upsetting online content. Talking about it can help.

ALERT!

Illegal content

Illegal content is content that breaks a country's laws. It is extremely offensive material that is placed online, and can include sites that encourage violence, criminal behavior, or dangerous behavior, such as creating weapons, taking or making drugs, or carrying out fraudulent or terrorist acts; highly graphic sexual acts that would be likely to offend a "reasonable adult"; and child abuse material.

Prohibited and illegal content can be found almost anywhere online, so it's sometimes hard to avoid and can be seen by accident. People should not look up illegal content online, even if they intend to report and remove it.